FirmsLedger — Technical SEO Audit

Why ~9,000 indexed pages aren't ranking — crawlability, indexability, content, linking, structured data, metadata, rendering, performance, and competitive diagnosis

Prepared 2026-08-06 · Read-only codebase + live-site audit · Companion to the user's own prioritized fix list

Recap: Already Fixed This Session (uncommitted, awaiting review)

#	Issue	File
F1	Canonical/OG tags defaulted to non-www domain, which itself 308-redirects to www — self-contradicting canonical on effectively all ~9,000 pages	`src/lib/seo.js:10`
F2	Noindexed `/search` was still listed in the sitemap	`app/sitemap.js`
F3	Indexable subcategory+state pages were missing from the sitemap entirely	`app/sitemap.js`
F4	Breadcrumb JSON-LD: two rungs pointed at the identical URL	`app/[category]/[state]/[subcategory]/page.jsx`
F5	Duplicate/broken sitewide `WebSite` schema targeting a dead `/Directory` URL	`app/layout.jsx`
F6	Homepage `SearchAction` targeted a redirect-only URL instead of the real search endpoint	`app/page.jsx`

These five files have local, uncommitted changes sitting in `git diff`. Nothing has been committed or deployed.

1. Crawlability

- **robots.txt** is clean but stale: disallows `/AdminDashboard`, `/AgencyProfile`, `/InviteAgency` — pre-Next-migration paths that no longer exist as routes. `/join` is disallowed but already 301-redirected before robots.txt would matter.
- **Crawl budget is spent oddly**: the header's category mega-menu and mobile menu render zero links in raw HTML (gated behind client state, default closed). `/browse` is a client-only shell — its initial HTML is a loading spinner. The footer is the only unconditional sitewide link source, and covers just 6/10 categories and 7/50 states.
- **Orphan pages, confirmed**: subcategory+state pages (thousands of URLs) have zero internal link path anywhere in the app — verified by grepping every possible link construction site-wide. Before this

session's sitemap fix (F3) they were undiscoverable short of URL guessing.

- **Crawl depth**: home → category-or-state hub → category+state → company is 3 clicks; subcategory+state is a 4th level, reachable only via sitemap. Windowed pagination means a company ranked #200 in a 500-listing page needs 8 "Next" clicks to reach from page 1.

2. Indexability

- **Duplicate URLs**: not a problem — filter query params correctly canonicalize back to the clean URL.
- **Soft 404s**: none found — `notFound()` fires correctly for empty combos, real HTTP 404.
- **Parameter handling**: clean, as above.
- **Faceted navigation**: `FilterBar.jsx` is 100% JS-driven — every filter is an `onClick` handler, and the submit action is a raw `window.location.href` redirect, not even a client-side `<Link>`. No filter combination is crawlable.
- **Pagination**: page ≥2 correctly `noindex, follow`. Out-of-range params (`?page=99`) return HTTP 200 with a title claiming "Page 99" while rendering page-1 content — a mismatch, low impact since unlinked.
- **HTTP status codes**: verified clean (200/404/308 all correct). The 404 page ships two conflicting `<meta name="robots">` tags (default `index,follow` plus a `noindex` override) — invalid to ship both, though `noindex` wins in practice.

3. Content Quality

Core finding: the ~500 category+state pages differ from each other by exactly one templated sentence with substituted numbers, plus the listing itself. The only genuinely unique prose in the category system (`cat.longDescription`) is gated to the 10 *nationwide* category pages only (`!stateName`) — deliberately excluded from every state-filtered variant. That's the textbook thin/near-duplicate-template pattern across 500+ URLs.

This isn't paper-thin content — the listing data itself is real and differentiated. But the wrapper around it is boilerplate, and at a ratio of 10 pages-with-real-prose to ~9,000 without, it reads as a doorway-page pattern to a quality classifier even though the underlying data is legitimate.

State hub pages have the same issue, more defensible since they're pure hubs. Company profiles are gated reasonably (must be approved + have a non-empty description) — but per `pipeline/DESCRIPTION_BACKFILL_PLAN.md` , **3,683 of ~10,474 companies (35%) remain unapproved** for lack of a description alone, i.e. over a third of inventory isn't indexed yet.

4. Internal Linking

- Homepage's real SSR link surface: only 4/10 category cards and 1/50 states (hardcoded default "california") have real links in raw HTML — the rest need a client click.
- Category+state pages link up to their category hub but never to their own state hub — the fix already exists as dead code (a sidebar block hardcoded off via `showStateFilter`). The two hub hierarchies never cross-reference at the leaf, so PageRank doesn't recirculate between them.

- Company profile pages — the deepest template in the site — link only up (category hub) and sideways (other companies), never to their own category+state page or state hub, despite having the data on hand.
- Pagination is windowed on category+state pages (only page 1, current±1, and last page linked) but unwindowed on subcategory+state pages — an inconsistency, and the windowed version starves deep-ranked companies of link equity.

5. Structured Data

- Homepage's duplicate `WebSite` schema conflict — already fixed (F5/F6).
- `Organization` (sitewide) and `ItemList` (listing pages) present and valid.
- `BreadcrumbList` present on category/state/subcategory listings and company profiles, but **missing entirely on state hub pages**, and only 2 levels deep on company profiles (Home → Company, skipping category/state).
- `LocalBusiness` present on company profiles — field completeness (address, phone, aggregateRating) not verified this pass.
- **Recommend**: add `BreadcrumbList` to state hub; extend company profile breadcrumb to 4 levels; verify `LocalBusiness` completeness; consider `FAQPage` schema once unique content is added to category+state pages.

6. Metadata

- Titles and descriptions are genuinely unique per page (verified across 5 category/state combos) — real dynamic substitution, not boilerplate.
- Several titles run 63–72 characters, over Google's practical ~60-char SERP display limit — a CTR/truncation issue, not a ranking penalty.
- OG and Twitter metadata complete on every template sampled.
- Category+state pages below the sitemap's 5-company threshold stay indexable if linked, despite being genuinely thin — the threshold currently gates the sitemap only, not indexability itself.

7. Rendering

- Listing/company templates are properly SSR'd — real company data verified present in raw HTML.
- Homepage and company profile are `'use client'` but server-fed via props/`initialData`, so content is present on first paint in the normal case.
- `/browse` is genuinely client-only — no content or links without JS execution, a real gap if it's meant to be indexable.
- Two large client components sit on the highest-traffic templates: `DirectoryHub.jsx` (689 lines, homepage) and `AgencyProfile.jsx` (834 lines, every company profile) — a hydration-cost concern more than an indexability one.

8. Performance

- `next/image` is used nowhere in the codebase, despite `next.config.mjs` already having `remotePatterns` configured for it. `CompanyCard` logos have decent manual sizing/lazy-loading; `AgencyProfile`'s hero logo and several other views have none — real CLS risk.
- Fonts are handled well (`next/font` , `display: swap` , self-hosted, no duplicate loading path).
- **Duplicate DB queries**: `generateMetadata` and the page body independently re-fetch the same data with no request-level memoization anywhere in `src/db/neonApi.js` — 2x DB round-trips per load on the two highest-traffic template types, affecting TTFB.
- `app/[category]/page.jsx` has a real, populated `generateStaticParams` completely overridden by `force-dynamic` — the most-linked, most-cacheable pages in the site are needlessly SSR'd every request.
- Company profile has a 4-stage sequential data-fetching chain plus its own duplicate lookup call — likely the slowest TTFB of the three main templates.
- 93 inline `style={{...}}` occurrences per render on the category+state template (~9,000 renders) — modest HTML bloat, inconsistent with Tailwind classes used elsewhere in the same file.
- Live Core Web Vitals measurement was blocked by a PageSpeed API daily quota this session — pull real numbers from Search Console's Core Web Vitals report instead (real-user data, no quota issue).

9. Competitive SEO

Thomasnet, Manta, and D&B all blocked programmatic access (403 bot protection); IndustryNet let requests through.

- **IndustryNet**: flat, alphabetical 150+ category structure, no search bar, heavy reliance on internal-link taxonomy alone, 2-3 clicks to a listing, visible trust signals ("since 1912," Fortune 500 logos). Its internal linking is actually simpler than FirmsLedger's — it leans entirely on decades of accumulated authority.
- **Thomasnet, Manta, D&B** — general knowledge, not fresh data: all three are 20-100+ year old domains with backlink profiles a young site cannot structurally match through on-page work alone. D&B in particular is primarily a data/credit business with thin, gated directory pages — a case where well-executed FirmsLedger pages could plausibly out-content it, if the authority gap weren't so large.

> **Honest diagnosis:** the fixes in this audit close FirmsLedger's *controllable* technical/content gap. They don't substitute for the *off-page* authority gap — that's backlink-building (already item #6 on the original priority list), a multi-month effort independent of any code change. Expect these fixes to matter more on long-tail category+state+subcategory queries than on head terms against these four competitors.

10. Top 20 Issues — Ranking Diagnosis

#	Severity	Issue	File(s)
1	**Critical**	Subcategory+state pages (thousands) have zero internal link path — sitemap-only discovery	`app/[category]/[state]/page.jsx`, `FilterBar.jsx`, `OtherCategoriesCard.jsx`
2	**Critical**	~500 category+state pages carry no unique content beyond one templated sentence; only real prose is nationwide-only	`app/[category]/[state]/page.jsx`
3	**High**	Company profiles never link to their own category+state page or state hub	`src/views/AgencyProfile.jsx`
4	**High**	Header nav + `/browse` contribute ~0 crawlable links/content in raw HTML	`src/Layout.jsx`, `src/views/Categories.jsx`
5	**High**	Category+state ↔ state hub cross-link missing — fix already exists in code, hardcoded off	`app/[category]/[state]/page.jsx:431,702`
6	**High**	Facet UI is 100% JS-driven — zero crawlable facet URLs	`src/components/listing/FilterBar.jsx`
7	**Medium**	Homepage SSR link surface: only 4/10 categories, 1/50 states in raw HTML	`src/views/DirectoryHub.jsx`
8	**Medium**	Duplicate DB queries per page load (metadata vs. body, no memoization)	`app/[category]/[state]/page.jsx`, `app/company/[slug]/page.jsx`, `src/db/neonApi.js`
9	**Medium**	`force-dynamic` overrides a real `generateStaticParams` on the 10 category hub pages	`app/[category]/page.jsx:9`
10	**Medium**	No `next/image` anywhere despite infra being half-configured; missing width/height in places	`AgencyProfile.jsx`, `Home.jsx`, `claim-listing/page.jsx`
11	**Medium**	Company profile breadcrumb JSON-LD only 2 levels deep	`app/company/[slug]/page.jsx:113-122`
12	**Medium**	State hub has no `BreadcrumbList` schema	`app/states/[slug]/page.jsx`
13	**Medium**	Windowed pagination starves deep-ranked companies of link equity	`app/[category]/[state]/page.jsx:78-100`
14	Low	93 inline `style={{}}` per render on the highest-volume template	`app/[category]/[state]/page.jsx`
15	Low	Titles run 63-72 chars on some templates, over ~60-char SERP display limit	listing metadata templates

16	Low	robots.txt disallows dead pre-migration paths	`app/robots.js`
17	Low	404 page ships two conflicting robots meta tags	`app/layout.jsx` / not-found page
18	Low	`?page=99` returns 200 with mismatched title vs. actual (page-1) content	`app/[category]/[state]/page.jsx`
19	Low	Thin (<5 company) category+state pages stay indexable if linked, despite sitemap omission	`app/sitemap.js` / `app/[category]/[state]/page.jsx`
20	*Off-page*	Domain authority/backlink gap vs. all 4 competitors — no code fix substitutes for this	n/a

Prioritized Remediation

Quick wins (< 1 hour each)

#5 re-enable the dead state-hub link block · #9 delete one line (`force-dynamic`) · #16 robots.txt cleanup · #17 fix conflicting 404 robots meta · #18 clamp `pageParam` before building title · #15 trim titles to ≤60 chars · #11 extend company breadcrumb · #12 add state hub `BreadcrumbList` · #8 wrap the two duplicated DB calls in `React.cache()`

Medium (1-2 days)

#3 company profile → category+state/state links · #1 & #6 together (real crawlable subcategory discovery path) · #4 SSR a base set of header/browse links · #10 `next/image` migration · #13 pagination fix or secondary discovery path · #19 decide + implement explicit noindex for thin pages

Long-term

#2 unique content authored per category+state (content project, not a code task) · #7 homepage browse UX redesign that SSRs more without hurting UX · #14 inline-style cleanup pass · #20 backlink building (off-page, multi-month)

FirmsLedger Technical SEO Audit — generated 2026-08-06. Read-only codebase and live-site investigation; no fixes beyond F1–F6 have been applied. All file:line citations verified against the working tree at time of audit.